

NBZ RESEARCH · INSTITUTIONAL DEEP DIVE



KAITO

\$ KAITO

AI-Powered InfoFi: Mapping the Attention
Economy of Web3

PRICE	MARKET CAP	FDV	RANK	CIRC. SUPPLY
\$0.679	\$163.9M	\$679M	#181	241.4M

RESEARCH BY NBZ / NASIR

Market data as of August 10-12, 2026 · Not financial advice

01PROJECT OVERVIEW

FIELD	DETAIL
Project Name	Kaito AI
Token Ticker	KAITO
Blockchain Layer	Layer 2 (application token; ERC-20 standard)
Built On	Base — Coinbase’s OP Stack Ethereum L2
Protocol Type	AI-powered InfoFi (Information Finance) platform
Founded	2022 (building began March 2022), Seattle, US
HQ	Seattle, US (team now distributed; founder based in Singapore)
TGE Date	February 20, 2025
Contract Address	0x98d0...7553 (Base) — verified on BaseScan
Website	kaito.ai
Total Raised	\$10.8M across Seed + Series A
Circulating Supply	241.39M KAITO (≈24.1% of max supply)
Max Supply	1.00B KAITO
Current Focus	Kaito Studio, Capital Launchpad, Attention Markets

Kaito AI positions itself as the infrastructure layer for what it calls the "attention economy" — the idea that in a world of GenAI-driven content abundance, the truly scarce resource is verified, high-quality attention. The project's core thesis, framed as "InfoFi" (Information Finance), is that creators, users, and brands currently generate the majority of value captured by centralized platforms, and that this value should instead be quantified, tokenized, and redistributed fairly among the people who actually produce and curate information.

The product began as a Web3-native search and research engine: an AI system that indexes fragmented crypto information — X/Twitter threads, governance forums, whitepapers, podcasts, and news — and turns it into structured, searchable intelligence for traders, funds, and analysts (branded Kaito Pro). Kaito's application token, KAITO, is deployed as an ERC-20 asset on Base, an Ethereum Layer-2 network built using Coinbase's OP Stack. Base was chosen for its low transaction costs and native alignment with Coinbase's distribution and liquidity.

What differentiates Kaito from a generic analytics dashboard is its "Mindshare" metric — an AI-derived score of how much authentic attention a project, narrative, or individual is capturing across crypto-native social channels at any given time. That metric became the backbone of Kaito's early growth engine (the Yaps points program) and now underpins its 2026 product suite: Kaito Studio, a curated creator-brand marketplace, and Attention Markets, a prediction-market partnership with Polymarket that lets users trade directly on mindshare and sentiment outcomes.

02TEAM & FOUNDERS

NAME	ROLE	BACKGROUND
Yu Hu	Founder & CEO	University of Cambridge graduate; investment banking analyst at Deutsche Bank; managed a ~\$500M long/short book as an analyst at Citadel; briefly traded at Millennium before leaving to build Kaito full-time in March 2022. Remained a pseudonymous/low-profile founder for roughly three years before becoming public-facing.
Yunzhong He	Co-Founder	Listed as Kaito's technical co-founder; detailed public background is limited relative to Yu Hu.
Sandra Leow	Research Partner	Previously a research manager at Nansen, an established on-chain analytics firm; brings direct crypto-research-industry experience.
Tianqi Wang	Business Development	Prior experience at Deutsche Bank and Credit Suisse in traditional finance.
Gareth Lee	Business Development	Public profile focused on BD; limited disclosed prior work history.
Jiwoo Jun	Business Development	Previously worked at Beoble, a Web3 social/chat platform.

Kaito's leadership carries genuine traditional-finance and quant credibility. Yu Hu's path through Deutsche Bank, Citadel, and Millennium is a meaningfully strong pedigree for a founder building market-intelligence infrastructure — it suggests real fluency in how institutional capital consumes information, which shows up directly in Kaito Pro's enterprise pricing (reported around \$833/month) and its 700+ claimed enterprise subscribers.

That said, the publicly visible team skews toward business development rather than deep technical or AI-research talent; core engineering leadership beyond Yunzhong He is not well documented in public sources, which is a modest transparency gap for a company describing itself as an AI infrastructure platform. Team size is estimated at roughly 30-35 employees (per third-party company trackers), which is lean relative to the scope of products now under Kaito's umbrella (search, creator marketplace, launchpad, prediction markets).

Yu Hu's multi-year period as an anonymous or low-profile founder is worth flagging honestly: it is not unusual in crypto, and he has since stepped into a public role (X, conference panels, fireside chats), but it does mean early investors and users initially had less founder-identity verification than is typical for a company later raising from Sequoia and Dragonfly.

03TECHNOLOGY & ARCHITECTURE

COMPONENT	DESCRIPTION
Blockchain Layer	Base — Ethereum L2 (OP Stack); KAITO is an ERC-20 token
Core Mechanism	LLM-driven aggregation of unstructured Web3 data into a quantified "Mindshare" attention score
Data Sources Indexed	X/Twitter, Discord, governance forums, Mirror, Medium, podcasts, conference transcripts, news sites
Flagship Products	Kaito Pro (search/analytics terminal), Kaito API, Kaito Studio, Capital Launchpad, Attention Markets
Developer Tools	Kaito API for programmatic data/mindshare access; select open-source client libraries under the kaito-project GitHub org
Smart Contract Audits	No publicly available third-party audit identified (e.g., from Certik, Trail of Bits, or similar); Base contract is verified on BaseScan but unaudited by a named security firm as of this report
Chain Abstraction / Oracles	Not a core feature; the platform is primarily an off-chain AI data layer with an on-chain token, rather than a multi-chain execution protocol
Roadmap Items	Bridging to Ethereum mainnet and deployment of on-chain governance modules (stated roadmap, not yet live)

In plain terms, Kaito's technology works by continuously scraping and processing large volumes of public and semi-public Web3 content, then using AI models to rank, cluster, and score that content for relevance, quality, and "attention" — producing the Mindshare metric that sits at the center of nearly every Kaito product. This is conceptually similar to a search-engine ranking algorithm, but tuned specifically for crypto-native discourse rather than the general web.

The core innovation is less about novel on-chain infrastructure and more about applying AI/NLP at scale to a historically fragmented and noisy information environment, then tying the output to real economic incentives (rewards, creator campaigns, prediction markets) via the KAITO token. This solves a genuine pain point: crypto information genuinely is scattered across dozens of channels with no native search layer, unlike the mainstream web.

The most material technology-risk gap is the absence of a published third-party smart contract audit. For a token with a circulating market cap in the hundreds of millions of dollars, this is a real diligence item; automated on-chain scanners have historically shown no formal audit on record for the Base contract, even though the contract itself is verified (meaning its source code is publicly viewable, which is a different and lower bar than an independent security review).

04USE CASES & REAL-WORLD APPLICATIONS

USE CASE	DESCRIPTION	STATUS
Web3 Meta-Search & Market Intelligence	Kaito Pro indexes and structures crypto-native information for funds, traders, and analysts	Live
Mindshare / Attention Analytics	AI-scored measurement of authentic attention for projects, narratives, and individuals	Live
Kaito Studio	Curated, tier-based marketplace connecting brands with vetted creators across X, YouTube, and TikTok, spanning crypto, finance, and AI verticals	Live
Capital Launchpad	Merit-based token sale platform allocating access by social reputation and on-chain history instead of first-come-first-served speed	Live
Attention Markets	Prediction markets (via Polymarket partnership) on mindshare and sentiment outcomes for brands, trends, and public figures	Live (Feb 2026)
Kaito Markets (standalone)	A dedicated, Kaito-owned attention-markets site, separate from the Polymarket integration	Roadmap
On-Chain Governance	KAITO holder voting on platform upgrades and ecosystem decisions	Roadmap

The most powerful near-term demand driver is Kaito Studio, launched in beta in February 2026 with 16 initial brand partners and expanded to a full launch in March 2026. It replaced the original Yaps "post-to-earn" program after X (formerly Twitter) revoked API access for applications that paid users to post — a structural shock that forced Kaito to pivot from an open, incentivized leaderboard to a selective, application-based creator marketplace judged on audience reach and campaign fit.

Attention Markets, live since February 2026 through the Polymarket partnership, represents Kaito's expansion from pure information services into direct capital markets built on its own data — letting users take financial positions on the very mindshare signals Kaito already generates. This is a genuine second revenue/utility vector beyond subscription-based search.

Governance and full on-chain integration remain roadmap items; as of this report, the KAITO token functions primarily as a utility and incentive-distribution asset rather than a governance instrument with live, binding on-chain votes.

05COMMUNITY & ECOSYSTEM

METRIC	DATA
Enterprise / Research Users	250,000+ platform users cited; 700+ paying Kaito Pro enterprise subscribers reported
Notable Institutional Users	Teams at Berachain, Polygon, Pantera, and 500+ other investment, marketing, and research organizations cited as users of Kaito's data
Kaito Studio Brand Partners	16 initial brand partners at February 2026 beta launch
Genesis NFT Program	Early community/loyalty NFT tier, used historically in airdrop allocation weighting
Exchange Listings	Binance, OKX, Coinbase, Kraken, Bybit, KuCoin, Bitget, Gate, MEXC, WhiteBIT, DigiFinex, LBank, BtcTurk, Deepcoin, Bittrue, CoinW, BYDFi, and others
Attention Markets Partner	Polymarket (live integration, February 2026)

Kaito Yaps and its incentivized leaderboards were fully sunset on January 15, 2026, following X's platform-wide policy change against apps that reward users for posting. Prior community-growth figures tied to Yaps should be read as historical rather than a live, ongoing incentive program.

Kaito's community traction shows real, if mixed, signals. The original Yaps engagement model genuinely bootstrapped a large and active user base and is widely credited as one of the platforms that defined the InfoFi category. However, that same model drew consistent criticism — echoed across multiple independent commentators — for content homogeneity, spam, and incentive-fairness concerns, which ultimately contributed to Kaito's decision to replace it entirely with the more selective, application-gated Kaito Studio.

The shift to a curated, brand-partner model is a reasonable response to those quality concerns, but it also means Kaito has voluntarily narrowed its top-of-funnel from "anyone can farm points" to "vetted creators only" — a trade-off between community breadth and content quality that will take several more quarters to evaluate. The claimed 250,000+ users and 700+ paying enterprise customers for Kaito Pro suggest genuine product-market fit on the institutional-research side, which is arguably a more durable growth signal than social-engagement volume alone.

06INVESTORS & PARTNERSHIPS

ROUND	DATE	AMOUNT	VALUATION	LEAD INVESTORS
Seed	Q1 2023	\$5.3M	Not disclosed	Sequoia Capital, Dragonfly, Mirana Ventures, Alpha Lab, others
Series A	June 22, 2023	\$5.5M	\$87.5M	The Spartan Group, Dragonfly (co-leads)
Total Raised	—	\$10.8M	\$87.5M (last round)	—

TIER	INVESTOR	TYPE
Tier 1	The Spartan Group (Lead)	Venture
Tier 1	Dragonfly (Lead)	Venture
Tier 1	Sequoia Capital	Venture
Tier 2	Mirana Ventures	Venture
Tier 3	Superscrypt (Lead)	Venture
Tier 3	Folius Ventures	Venture
Tier 3	DWeb3 Capital	Venture
Tier 3	Caladan	Venture
Tier 3	Jane Street Capital	Venture
Tier 4	Smrti Lab	Hedge Fund
Tier 4	Taurus Ventures	Venture
Other	Time Research	Venture / Research

Kaito's cap table is genuinely elite by crypto-startup standards. Sequoia Capital's participation is notable because the firm invests selectively in crypto-native projects, and Dragonfly and the Spartan Group are among the most active and well-regarded crypto-focused funds globally. The presence of Jane Street Capital — a quantitative trading firm rather than a typical venture investor — is a distinctive signal, suggesting a market-structure/liquidity-oriented backer took a direct interest in Kaito's data and market-intelligence thesis.

Beyond capital, this investor roster carries real strategic value: Dragonfly and Sequoia both have deep networks across the funds and protocols that are Kaito's target enterprise customers for Kaito Pro, effectively doubling as a distribution channel. The multi-tier structure (four tiers plus "other") also indicates a broad, oversubscribed round rather than a small handful of checks, which is generally a healthier sign of syndicate demand than concentration in one or two funds.

07

TOKENOMICS

PARAMETER	VALUE
Ticker	KAITO
Standard	ERC-20 (Base)
Max / Total Supply	1,000,000,000 KAITO
Circulating Supply	241,388,889 KAITO (≈24.1%)
TGE Date	February 20, 2025
Next Major Unlock	~August 20, 2026 — 32.6M KAITO (≈\$21.2M, ~3.3% of supply)

CATEGORY	%	NOTES
Ecosystem & Network Growth	32.16%	Largest single bucket; funds long-term incentive programs
Core Contributors	24.99%	Team allocation, subject to vesting
Foundation	10.00%	Treasury / foundation reserve
Initial Community and Ecosystem Claim	10.00%	Distributed at/around TGE (Yaps + Genesis NFT holders)
Early Backers	8.33%	Seed and Series A investors, subject to vesting
Long-term Creator Incentives	7.50%	Ongoing creator/community rewards, still unlocking
Liquidity Incentives	5.00%	Exchange and DEX liquidity support
Binance Hodler	2.00%	Binance HODLer Airdrop allocation (BNB Simple Earn subscribers)

At a headline level, the distribution is reasonably balanced: roughly 42% is earmarked for ecosystem growth and community/creator incentives combined (Ecosystem & Network Growth, Long-term Creator Incentives, and the Initial Community claim), versus roughly 33% for insiders (Core Contributors plus Early Backers). This is not an unusually insider-heavy split by current market standards, though the 24.99% Core Contributors allocation is still a meaningful bloc that will add sell-pressure as it vests.

The main unlock-overhang risk is straightforward: with only about 24% of max supply currently circulating, roughly three-quarters of KAITO's total 1 billion supply is still to enter the market over time. The next scheduled unlock (~August 20, 2026) alone represents 3.3% of total supply in a single event — a meaningful one-day liquidity test relative to KAITO's current ~\$164M market cap.

Token demand is driven primarily by utility rather than a hard deflationary mechanism: staking for platform benefits, participation in Capital Launchpad (which appears to require holding or staking KAITO), and access tiers within Kaito Studio and Attention Markets. No public burn mechanism was identified in available sources, meaning KAITO is not currently structured as a deflationary asset — its long-term value accrual depends on sustained platform usage and fee/subscription capture rather than supply reduction.

08MARKET OVERVIEW

METRIC	VALUE
Current Price	\$0.679 (as of Aug 10, 2026)
24h Range	\$0.660 – \$0.709
Market Cap	\$163.9M
Fully Diluted Valuation	≈\$679M
24h Volume	≈\$38.7M
All-Time High	\$2.919 (Feb 27, 2025)
All-Time Low	\$0.2714
Market Cap Rank	~#164-#211 (varies by data provider)
Circulating Supply	241.39M KAITO
Key Exchange Listings	Binance, OKX, Coinbase, Kraken, Bybit, KuCoin, Bitget, Gate, MEXC

KAITO's price history is a fairly typical high-beta airdrop token arc. The token launched via TGE on February 20, 2025 amid strong anticipation from its Yaps community and elite investor backing, and rallied to an all-time high of \$2.919 just one week later on February 27, 2025, fueled by airdrop-driven demand and the broader AI-token narrative that was dominant in early 2025.

From that peak, KAITO entered a prolonged drawdown consistent with the broader 2025 correction across AI and InfoFi tokens, eventually touching an all-time low of \$0.2714 before stabilizing. As of early August 2026, KAITO trades around \$0.68 — roughly 71% below its all-time high, though still well above its post-launch floor, suggesting a base of demand has formed even as the token has re-rated sharply lower from its launch euphoria.

Relative to Kaito's last private valuation of \$87.5M (Series A, June 2023), the current fully diluted valuation of roughly \$679M represents a substantial premium — nearly 8x the last private mark. This is a common pattern for tokens that priced their public listing well above prior private rounds, and it means public-market holders are, in effect, paying a meaningfully higher implied valuation than venture investors did, even after the ~71% drawdown from ATH.

09COMPETITORS & MARKET POSITION

PROJECT	TYPE / CHAIN	POSITIONING VS. KAITO
Cookie.fun / COOKIE (Cookie DAO)	InfoFi / AI-agent analytics	Most direct competitor; more open scoring algorithm with loyalty weighting, gamified "Snaps" mechanic, positions itself as more decentralized and community-governed than Kaito's AI-led model
Ethos	On-chain reputation markets	Adjacent rather than head-on; focused on trust/reputation scoring for individuals and projects via a tradable "trust ticket" market rather than mindshare/attention scoring
SoSoValue	AI-driven crypto data platform	Listed by third-party trackers as a top competitor in AI-powered crypto information services
Nansen / Messari	Institutional on-chain & research analytics	Adjacent, more established institutional research incumbents; do not focus specifically on social "mindshare" scoring the way Kaito does

Kaito sits at the center of the InfoFi category it helped originate, and its combination of an AI-driven search product, elite investor backing, and now a diversified suite (Studio, Capital Launchpad, Attention Markets) gives it a broader product moat than single-purpose competitors like Cookie.fun, which remains primarily focused on social-engagement scoring and gamification.

Cookie.fun is the most direct like-for-like competitor and has explicitly marketed itself as solving the transparency and fairness complaints leveled at Kaito's original Yaps model, positioning around a more open algorithm and community governance roadmap. Whether that translates into durable market share depends on execution rather than positioning alone; both platforms are still relatively young.

The single biggest competitive threat is commoditization: "mindshare" and "attention scoring" are conceptually reproducible, and multiple InfoFi entrants launched with lower or no participation thresholds than Kaito's tightened Yaps rules, effectively competing away Kaito's original growth-loop advantage. Kaito's pivot toward enterprise subscriptions (Kaito Pro), merit-based fundraising (Capital Launchpad), and prediction markets (Attention Markets) can be read as a strategic move to build moats beyond the easily-copied attention-scoring mechanic itself.

10RECENT NEWS & UPDATES

DATE	EVENT
March 2022	Yu Hu begins building Kaito AI in Seattle after leaving Millennium
Q1 2023	Seed round closed, \$5.3M (Sequoia Capital, Dragonfly, Mirana Ventures, Alpha Lab, others)
June 20, 2023	Private beta launched to 35,000 waitlisted users
June 22, 2023	Series A closed, \$5.5M at an \$87.5M valuation (Spartan Group and Dragonfly co-leads)
Feb 14, 2025	\$KAITO token and whitepaper officially announced
Feb 19, 2025	Binance HODLer Airdrop announcement; KAITO TGE confirmed for Feb 20
Feb 20, 2025	Token Generation Event; airdrop claims open 12:00 UTC, trading begins 13:00 UTC across Binance, OKX, KuCoin, Bitget, Gate, MEXC, WhiteBIT, DigiFinex
Feb 21, 2025	Coinbase announces support for KAITO on Base
Feb 27, 2025	KAITO reaches all-time high of \$2.919
March 2025	Kraken listing; deeper Base-network integration
April 2025	Kaito Pro premium institutional analytics suite launched
July 21, 2025	gKAITO rewards mechanism introduced (Thought Leadership, Attention, Participation, Ownership, Culture)
Jan 15, 2026	Yaps and incentivized Yapper Leaderboards sunset following X's API policy change against pay-to-post apps
Feb 2026	Kaito Studio launches in beta (16 initial brand partners); Attention Markets launches via Polymarket partnership
March 2026	Kaito Studio moves from beta to full launch
Aug 20, 2026	Next scheduled major token unlock: ~32.6M KAITO (≈\$21.2M, ~3.3% of supply)

The timeline reveals a team that ships and, importantly, is willing to sunset its own flagship growth mechanism when it stops working rather than propping it up. The Yaps-to-Studio transition inside a single month (announced Jan 15, live in beta by February 2026) is a fast pivot by crypto-startup standards, especially given it followed an external shock (X's API policy change) rather than an internally planned migration.

The pattern since TGE also shows steady, incremental product expansion — Kaito Pro, gKAITO, Capital Launchpad, Studio, Attention Markets — roughly once per quarter, rather than a single big product bet. That cadence suggests reasonable execution discipline, though it also means the company has changed its core value proposition more than once within 18 months of its token launch, which newer or less-engaged token holders may not have fully tracked.

11INVESTMENT POTENTIAL & RISKS

+ Bull Case

- Category-defining first mover in InfoFi with real, paying enterprise customers (~\$833/mo Kaito Pro, 700+ subscribers claimed)
- Elite venture syndicate (Sequoia, Dragonfly, Spartan Group, Jane Street) signals strong institutional confidence and distribution support
- Demonstrated willingness to pivot fast (Yaps → Studio) rather than defend a broken growth mechanism
- Diversifying utility beyond search: Capital Launchpad and Attention Markets add new revenue/demand vectors for the token
- Deployed on Base, giving access to Coinbase-aligned liquidity and low-cost Ethereum L2 infrastructure
- Founder's Citadel/Deutsche Bank pedigree is directly relevant to building institutional-grade market intelligence tools

– Bear Case

- No publicly available third-party smart contract audit identified as of this report — a real security/trust gap for a ~\$164M market cap asset
- Platform-dependency risk already materialized once (X API revocation forced the Yaps shutdown) and could recur
- Token down roughly 71% from its Feb 2025 ATH; FDV (~\$679M) still sits well above the last private valuation (\$87.5M)
- ~76% of max supply still locked, with material unlock events (e.g., 3.3% of supply on Aug 20, 2026) creating ongoing sell pressure
- Growing InfoFi competition (Cookie.fun/COOKIE, Ethos) risks commoditizing the core "attention scoring" mechanic
- Small, BD-heavy public team with limited disclosed technical/AI leadership beyond the co-founders

RISK FACTOR	DETAILED EXPLANATION
Smart Contract / Audit Risk	No named third-party audit firm has published a report on the Base contract; verification on BaseScan confirms source-code visibility only, not independent security review
Platform Dependency Risk	Kaito's original growth engine depended on X API access, which was revoked platform-wide in January 2026, forcing a full product pivot; similar dependency risk could resurface with other data sources
Token Unlock / Supply Overhang	Only ~24% of max supply is circulating; scheduled unlocks (e.g., ~3.3% of supply on Aug 20, 2026) represent recurring liquidity tests against current volume
Competitive Risk	Cookie.fun, Ethos, and other InfoFi entrants are targeting the same attention/reputation-scoring niche, some with more open or lower-threshold models
Valuation Risk	Current FDV is roughly 8x Kaito's last private valuation; public-market holders bear meaningfully more downside risk than the venture round did
Execution / Team Risk	Public team roster is concentrated in business development roles; core technical/AI leadership is less publicly documented, adding uncertainty to long-term product execution

NBZ Research Verdict

Kaito is a legitimate category leader with elite backers, real paying customers, and a demonstrated ability to pivot when a core mechanism breaks — qualities that separate it from most attention-farming clones. The Yaps-to-Studio transition, while forced by X's policy shift, was executed quickly and shows discipline rather than denial. That said, KAITO the token still carries real risk: an unaudited contract, a heavy unlock schedule against roughly 76% of supply still locked, and a fully diluted valuation multiples above the company's last private round.

Conditions that would strengthen the bull case: a published third-party audit, sustained growth in Kaito Pro's paying enterprise base, and evidence that Attention Markets and Capital Launchpad generate durable fee revenue rather than one-off engagement spikes. The most critical near-term risk is supply overhang colliding with a still-uncertain revenue base. Positioning: KAITO is best suited to investors comfortable with high-beta, narrative-driven InfoFi exposure and prepared for continued volatility around unlock events — not a low-risk, cash-flow-backed holding.

Not financial advice.

DATA SOURCES

CoinGecko · Bybit · OKX · Kraken · Coinbase · MEXC · MarketBeat · CoinMarketCap · ICO Drops · CryptoRank · Messari · Tracxn · Dealroom · IQ.wiki · The Org · RootData · BeInCrypto · ChainCatcher · Gate Learn · CoinCu · Web3@KAIST research report · user-provided CoinMarketCap app screenshots (price/market/allocation/investor/team data) · docs.kaito.ai (official whitepaper) · kaito.ai (official website)